Who Represents the Destination, and What Do They Evaluate? Social-Media Posts about Qingdao

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Abstract. ~~Destination marketers and researchers frequently interpret social-media posts~~ Social-media posts are often read as direct proxies for ~~the destination imageheld by tourists. Conceptualizing~~ tourists' destination image. Treating posts as produced discourse ~~rather than static cognitive images, this extended abstract examines~~ instead, we examine how institutional accounts and individual creators portray ~~a single destination, Qingdao. We cleaned 19~~Qingdao. Cleaning reduced 11,~~099 posts and retained~~ 599 Qingdao tourism-related posts from four platforms to 10,178 ~~for formal use on four platforms, after low-quality Bilibili postswere droppeddestination-relevant posts~~. In a pilot ~~analysis~~ of 100 posts (476 segments), practical trip-planning information ~~predominated~~ (58% of segments) ~~, whereas~~ outweighed affective and sensory ~~expressions were less frequent~~ expression (30%). ~~Evaluations of core attractions were overwhelmingly favourable~~ Core attractions were judged overwhelmingly favourably (155 of 166 evaluations), whereas operational ~~aspects—price~~aspects such as price, service, ~~accessibility, and crowding—were~~ and crowding were evenly divided (20 ~~favourable~~ vs. 19~~unfavourable). The subsequent stage investigates whether institutional and individual creator groups project divergent destination images from identical resources.~~).

Keywords: destination image · user-generated content · content creators · content analysis.

1 Background

Destination image ~~comprises~~ is the cumulative beliefs and impressions ~~an individual~~ a person holds about a place ~~, which~~ and cannot be reduced to ~~simple aggregate~~ content frequencies [5]. ~~While social-media posts provide foundational~~ Social-media posts supply material for image formation [2] and can be coded for cognitive and affective attributes [1], ~~an online~~ but a post is not ~~identical to the internal cognitive image held by a visitor . Prior research~~ the image a visitor holds. Studies contrasting official marketing with tourist-generated content ~~has largely focused on thematic presence via word-frequency metrics~~have mostly measured thematic presence through word frequencies [4]. ~~Consequently, less~~ Less is known about ~~discursive variations in how destinations are represented: what pragmatic functions a post serves~~what a post does, which attributes it evaluates, and how creator identity shapes ~~the narrative~~both.

2 Purpose

~~This study investigates~~ We compare how institutional accounts and individual creators represent Qingdao~~by examining~~ : their communicative strategies, the ~~specific~~ resources and attributes ~~evaluated, and their co-occurrence within discrete~~ they evaluate, and how these co-occur within text segments. We hypothesize that, even when depicting identical destination resources, institutional posts consistently lean toward uncritical, promotional representation, whereas individual creators temper generally positive accounts with pragmatic caveats, critiques, or advice.

3 Method

We employ theory-driven structured content analysis [3]. ~~Segments are produced by semantic segmentation of the posttext, and each segment~~ Before coding, each post's text is divided into segments that each convey one self-contained point, using embedding-based semantic segmentation (Qwen3-Embedding-8B) constrained by fixed boundary rules; coders do not alter segment boundaries. Each segment is coded for rhetorical strategy, target destination resource, evaluative attribute, and the valence and intensity of the evaluation. Account metadata are ~~catalogued independently of textual codes~~coded separately, and creator grouping criteria were ~~pre-registered before inspecting comparative group outcomes. Trained~~ fixed before any group comparison. A relevance classifier trained on 1,300 ~~annotated posts , the cleaning model retained 10~~manually labelled posts screened the 11,~~178 posts for formal use on four platforms , after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. The pilot sample was coded independently by two trained human coders (inter-coder reliability~~ 599 Qingdao tourism-related posts collected from four platforms and retained 10,178 as destination-relevant. Two trained coders coded the pilot sample independently (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$ for evaluative direction~~reached Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$) , with discrepancies resolved through consensus discussions to establish the final labels~~) and resolved discrepancies by discussion.

4 Results to Date

~~*Filtering destination-relevant content.* Of 19,099 cleaned posts, 10,178 on four platforms were retained for formal use after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. Keyword-matched counts therefore overstate the posts actually used.~~

What posts do. The pilot ~~sample~~ covers 100 randomly sampled posts ~~across (~~476 segments~~)~~. Practical information (itineraries, pricing, how-to advice) appears in 58% of segments, sensory or emotional rendering in 30%, background knowledge in 11%, and calls for interaction in 3%. Approximately half of the posts convey explicit recommendations.

What posts judge. The ~~two human coders concurred on both the target attribute and evaluative valence across~~ coders agreed on both attribute and valence for 216 evaluations. Core attraction quality, activities, and destination atmosphere accounted for 166 evaluations (155 favourable vs. 10 unfavourable). Conversely, operational factors—price, service, facilities, accessibility, crowding, and management—accounted for 44 evaluations, with sentiment evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable).

~~*Where categories blur.* The coders diverged most frequently on whether visiting a landmark constitutes an activity versus a sight, and whether specific architectural structures function as scenic sights or service facilities. Consequently, the refined coding codebook explicitly separates scenic architectural attractions from functional hospitality facilities.~~

5 Significance

~~For destination marketing organizations (DMOs), this pilot untangles critical operational nuances that aggregate sentiment scores obscure. Favourable evaluations predominantly attach to endowed destination~~ Favourable evaluations attach mostly to endowed assets, whereas complaints concentrate on manageable operational touchpoints; ~~thus, actionable managerial signals reside within~~ the actionable signal for destination marketing organizations (DMOs) thus lies in roughly one-fifth of ~~all evaluations. Furthermore, posts function predominantly as pragmatic travel-planning utilities rather than purely affective personal reflections. If subsequent full-sample analysis confirms that individual creators absorb and project operational critiques while institutional accounts omit them, the two cohorts effectively construct divergent destinations from the same underlying resources. Aligned with the conference theme of Hype and Return, our methodology demonstrates where computational automation delivers efficiency and where rigorous human discernment remains indispensable~~evaluations, which aggregate sentiment scores obscure. Speaking to the theme *Shaping Tourism Technology: Hype, Human Centricity and ROI*, models handle the high-volume steps of relevance filtering and segmentation, while human coders make the interpretive judgements. Social-listening tools that report evaluations by attribute and creator type, rather than as one sentiment score, would show DMOs where operational investment pays off.

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